# British Columbia — Starting a Small Business

*Quick Reference Checklist: Name, Domain, GST & PST*

*Jane Reitsma is not a licensed accountant or financial advisor. This is general information only — not legal or tax advice. Confirm current rules with a CPA and the official government sites before registering. Compiled July 2026.*

## ☐ Step 1: Search your name idea before you fall in love with it

- Google it (and try Bing too) — see who else is already using it, and whether it's easy to find or buried under similar results.
- Optional deeper check: search the Canadian Trademarks Database to see if the name (or something close) is already trademarked.
- Say it out loud, check for awkward abbreviations, and make sure it's easy to spell from hearing it once.

## ☐ Step 2: Check domain (URL) availability before you commit

- Search your name — and a few close variations — on GoDaddy and Rebel.ca (Rebel is a Canadian registrar — good for locking down a .ca domain).
- A name with no available domain is a name worth reconsidering — your domain is your business's home base.

## ☐ Step 3: Choose your name and register 3 options with BC Registry

- If you're operating as a sole proprietor under your own exact legal name (e.g., "Jane Reitsma," with nothing added), BC doesn't require you to register a business name at all — skip to Step 4. This step is only needed if you're using something else, like "The Money Organizer."
- Once your name idea has cleared Steps 1 and 2, prepare **3 name variations**, ranked in your order of preference — BC will consider them in that order if your first choice isn't approved.
- Submit a Name Request through BC Registry Services. Cost: $30 standard, or $100 for priority processing (1–2 business days).
- **You'll receive an email** once your request has been processed (approved or rejected) — check your inbox and spam folder.
- An approved name is reserved for **56 days**. Use that window to register your business structure (sole proprietorship, partnership, or incorporation) at bcregistry.gov.bc.ca — see the sole proprietorships & partnerships guide if you're going that route.

## ☐ Step 4: Project your sales to know when GST and PST kick in

- **GST/HST (federal):** register once your worldwide taxable revenue exceeds $30,000 in a single calendar quarter or over the trailing four quarters. Below that, registration is optional — voluntary registration lets you claim input tax credits on start-up costs.

- **PST (BC):** register once your gross revenue from B.C. sales exceeds $10,000 in the past 12 months, or immediately if you don't qualify as a "small seller" regardless of revenue (see Step 5).
- Rule of thumb: if you're projecting more than ~$2,500/month in sales, you'll likely cross the GST threshold within your first year — plan your pricing and invoicing accordingly.

## ☐ Step 5: Know who needs to register for PST (BC overview)

- **Register regardless of revenue** if, in the ordinary course of business in B.C., you: sell or lease taxable goods, provide software, provide "related services" (repair, install, or assemble taxable goods), provide legal services, or provide telecommunication services.
- **"Small seller" exception:** you may skip registration if you have no fixed business premises, aren't a lessor or independent sales contractor, and your gross B.C. sales were $10,000 or less over the past 12 months. This exception is narrow — most home-based or online sellers with a regular operation still need to register.
- **Pure service businesses** that don't fall into the categories above (most consulting, coaching, freelance writing/design) generally don't need to register for PST at all — only GST applies.

> **Heads-up for bookkeeping/coaching businesses:** BC Budget 2026 expands PST to certain professional services — including accounting services, bookkeeping, and assurance services — effective October 1, 2026. If your business (or a service you offer) falls into that category, check the province's Notice 2026-001 for registration timelines.

- Full "Who needs to register" list (Province of BC) — the complete, current breakdown by category.

## ☐ Step 6: Register for GST and PST

- **GST/HST:** Register through CRA Business Registration Online — get your federal Business Number (BN) first, then add a GST/HST program account. Instant confirmation.
- **PST:** Register online via eTaxBC (15–25 minutes) — you'll need your BN, ID, and an estimate of annual taxable sales. Processing can take up to 21 business days; once approved you'll get a PST number (format PST-1234-5678) and, if you enrolled in eTaxBC, a follow-up email with an enrolment code.

## ☐ Step 7: Know the rules if you sell online or ship across Canada

- Where your customer lives usually matters more than where your business is registered — this is called the "place of supply" rule, and it determines which province's tax rate you charge.
- For physical goods shipped to another province, you generally charge that destination province's tax rate — not your home province's rate.
- For digital products and services (online courses, templates, downloads, virtual coaching), the CRA generally sources the sale to the customer's billing address — the same rule applies.
- **If you only charge GST/HST (no separate PST/RST/QST):** your invoicing tool just needs the client's province on file to apply the right rate automatically — most tools, including My Money Organizer and QuickBooks, handle this once you enter the correct billing address.
- **If you're also PST-registered:** provincial sales tax generally follows narrower rules about where goods are delivered or services are performed, not just billing address — confirm with a CPA before scaling multi-province sales.
- CRA: Place of Supply in a Province — Overview — the full rules by product/service type.

## ☐ Step 8: Look into business insurance before you take on clients

- Business insurance isn't legally required to register, but most professionals carry it before their first invoice goes out — it protects you (and your clients) if something goes wrong.

- **Commercial general liability (CGL):** covers claims of bodily injury or property damage — a common baseline even for home-based and online service businesses.
- **Professional liability / errors & omissions (E&O):** worth a close look if you give advice, consulting, coaching, bookkeeping, or design services — it covers claims that your work caused a client financial loss, even if you did nothing wrong.
- **Home-based business coverage:** a standard homeowner's or tenant's policy typically excludes business equipment and liability — ask your insurer about adding a rider or a separate business policy if you work from home.
- **If you hire employees or subcontractors:** registering with WorkSafeBC is mandatory in most industries — coverage for sole proprietors who work alone is usually optional.
- Not sure where to start? Insurance Bureau of Canada is a good starting point for finding a licensed broker.
- This isn't insurance advice — a licensed insurance broker can match coverage to your specific business and risk level.

## Accounting: My Money Organizer vs. QuickBooks

Every business needs the same answer here: start with the right-sized tool, and upgrade when the complexity justifies it. The question isn't which tool is "better" — it's what your business actually needs right now.

### Stick with My Money Organizer while:

- You're a sole proprietor or solo operator with no employees or subcontractors on payroll.
- Invoicing is simple — a manageable number of clients, one currency, no progress billing or complex payment schedules.
- You don't carry inventory or need cost-of-goods-sold tracking.
- You only need to file one sales tax return (e.g., just GST, or GST + BC PST) and are comfortable doing it yourself with clear projections.
- You want one spreadsheet that shows income, expenses, tax set-asides, and budgeting in plain language — without learning full accounting software.

### Move to QuickBooks when:

- You hire an employee or contractor and need payroll (source deductions, T4s/T4As, ROEs).
- You carry inventory and need cost tracking, reorder points, or product-level profitability.
- You sell in multiple provinces and need to track and remit more than one sales tax.
- You want automatic bank-feed reconciliation, class/project tracking, or deeper reports (P&L, cash flow forecasting, budgets vs. actuals).
- Your accountant asks for direct QuickBooks Online access to prepare your return or year-end.

Not sure which fits your situation, or want help setting either one up?

**Book a free discovery call at themoneyorganizer.ca**